

Topic E1: The World in Crisis, 1879-1941

The focus of this topic is on international relations in the late 19th and the first half of the 20th century and why these relations broke down producing two devastating world wars. The key areas of study required for Section A are summarised in the four bullet points and the two associated controversies to be examined in Section B are clearly delimited underneath in the specification. Collectively, they offer a framework for understanding the period as a whole.

Although the bullet points have been treated separately here in terms of clarification, students should appreciate that links might be required in answering a question. For example, one on the pursuit of disarmament might require students to draw on bullet points 1 and 4.

The first bullet point relates to the build up of two diplomatic groupings in Europe and the onset of an arms race between the great powers. Students should understand why imperial Germany and the dual monarchy of Austria-Hungary formed an alliance in 1879 and how and why this alliance operated and survived and gained the addition of Italy to become the Triple Alliance. They should understand the coming together of France and Russia in the 1890s to form the Dual Alliance and the German response in evolving the Schlieffen Plan. They should be aware of Britain's dalliance with the Triple Alliance in the 1890s and her reconciliation with France and Russia in the ententes of 1904 and 1907, leading to limited military engagement in terms of planning and the naval agreement with France in 1912. They should be aware of the accelerating expenditure on armaments and in particular the great naval race between Germany and Britain and its diplomatic consequences.

The second bullet point relates to the series of international crises in the nine years before the outbreak of war in August 1914. Students should understand the nature of these crises and why all were settled peacefully prior to that of the summer of 1914. They should be aware of the significance of the first Moroccan crisis and the subsequent Algeiras Conference, the renewed tension over Morocco in 1911 and its peaceful resolution, the Bosnian crisis of 1908-09 and its impact on Russo-German relations, and the Balkan Wars of 1912-13 and the consequences for great power relations. Students should understand the evolution of the 1914 crisis from the assassination of Franz Ferdinand on the 28th June to the British declaration of war on 4th August and why diplomacy failed to contain tensions and rivalries on this occasion.

The third bullet point relates to the peace settlement after the First World War. Students do not need specific knowledge of the conduct of the war but should be aware of the cost in terms of men and money and the international agreements entered into by the belligerent powers which had a bearing on the post-war settlement, for example the Sykes-Picot Pact of 1916 relating to the Middle East, and commitments and pronouncements from individual countries affecting the post-war settlement, for example the Balfour Declaration of 1917 and Wilson's Fourteen Points of January 1918. Students should understand the differing national interests and principles operating in 1918-19 and how these shaped the treaties of Versailles, Trianon, Neuilly and Lausanne. In addition to understanding the positions of the major powers, Britain, France, the USA and Germany, students should understand the attitudes of, and results for, Italy, Turkey, Japan, China and the new USSR.

The fourth bullet point relates to the specific issue of armaments in the inter-war years and the attempts to avoid an arms race, perceived as so damaging in the period before 1914. Students should understand the process of disarmament with knowledge of the relevant clauses of the Treaty of Versailles and the subsequent attempts to achieve international disarmament even among the victors, with particular focus on the Washington Naval Conference and Treaty of 1921-22 and the Geneva Disarmament Conference of 1932-33. They should be aware of the reasons for the success of the former and the failure of the latter. They should have knowledge of the process of re-armament and the various attempts to moderate and control this development eg the Anglo-German Naval Agreement of 1935.